every day". Arrest meant certain torture and almost certain death. To survive, they needed to play a role at all times, scrupulously monitoring every detail of their behaviour to ensure they were not attracting attention to themselves as in any way unusual or foreign. To make anything happen they had to contact local people, but every contact brought the risk of betrayal – for opposition to the Nazi occupiers was nothing like as universal as SOE had naively assumed. Under pressure, some agents seemed to forget their common sense and much of their training. They wrote down codes or addresses that they were supposed to memorize, carried identity documents for two different aliases at the same time, or even spoke openly to one another in English in public places. On the other hand, some blended into their surroundings and sustained false identities even under suspicious cross-questioning.



Women at war
The SOE deployed many female agents in the war. Some were tasked with sabotage or radio operating duties *(left)*, but most were successfully used as couriers.



Covert communication
The Type 3 MK II suitcase radio was used by SOE agents in the field to communciate with HQ. Coded transmissions constantly evolved to avoid detection by the Nazis.

SUCCESSES AND FAILURES

Among SOE's most notable operations was the assassination of Reinhard Heydrich, deputy chief of the Gestapo. He was shot in Prague by two agents, Jan Kubis and Josef Gabcik, parachuted in by SOE in May 1942. In reprisal the Germans murdered some 5,000 Czech civilians; Kubis and Gabcik also died, betrayed by a fellow agent who had changed sides. A more clear-cut example of success was the sabotage of Norsk Hydro plant in occupied Norway in February 1943; it was producing heavy water, which could have been used by the Germans to make an atomic bomb. Norwegian SOE agents not only blew up the plant but also later sank a ferry carrying a consignment of heavy water destined for Germany.

Some SOE operations, however, were costly fiascos, none worse than the abortive effort to run a network in the Netherlands from 1942 to 1944. The first agents sent in were betrayed by a Dutch collaborator and German intelligence cracked their communication codes. An arrested SOE radio operator agreed to send messages for the Germans, carefully omitting security checks in order to alert his home section to the fact that he had been "turned". Inexplicably, senior SOE officers ignored the lack of security checks in the messages they were receiving and sent in agents and supplies to rendezvous fixed by the Nazis. More than 50 agents had fallen into German hands before the deception was discovered.

LARGE-SCALE RESISTANCE

By 1944 SOE was providing support and supplies for substantial resistance movements conducting rural guerrilla warfare in Yugoslavia, Greece, and the "maquis" of southern France. Although the SOE had not created these movements, the presence of SOE agents clearly raised morale, and the weaponry they supplied encouraged offensive operations that tied down large numbers of German troops. One of the SOE's finest hour's probably came with the Normandy landings in June 1944, when SOE agents and the French resistance succeeded in providing important intelligence on German defences and sabotaging transport links to block the movement of German reinforcements to Normandy.

Hundreds of SOE agents died in Nazi torture chambers and concentration camps in the course of the war. In France, for example, the death rate for agents was around one in four. Whether the organization's achievements were worth the cost is an impossible calculation. However, it is clear that SOE agents showed as much bravery as any soldier on the field of battle.



SOE weaponry
SOE's laboratory in Hertfordshire, in the UK, designed a variety of concealed weapons, ranging from gas pens to cigarette pistols. However, many agents were equipped only with conventional pistols.